

FN: One or two inspiring stories from the past 2-3 years?

JG: That's a tough one... the last few years were pretty rough with Covid. But during these years, I was organising Software Freedom Day in our local hackerspace.

In 2021, I was very inspired by the people from OpenStreetMap, and how they managed to mobilise a worldwide community to create maps that are freely available. We had the lead developer of FreeCAD who came to give an advanced talk on scripting in FreeCAD. He's a professional architect creating all his designs in FreeCAD. Just before that, one of our members gave an introduction on how to use that same program for 3D printing. I was touched by the versatility of FOSS and how different people use it in very different ways.

Last year there was an interesting talk about IoT, and how you could examine an existing device and intercept the traffic to go to your own server instead of to some cloud service.

FN: What is SFD's ultimate goal, and has it evolved over the years, considering that the focus on 'freedom' seems to have somewhat waned over time?

JG: Software freedom is, and has always been, a mindset — it's about believing in the importance of the four freedoms: the right to freely use software, to study it, to share it, and to alter it to your own needs.

While these four freedoms have remained the same, the reasons and accents have shifted. In the beginning of the millennium, it was all about having access to the tools. There were the haves and the have nots. I still remember walking in a Hong Kong market square, where they sold CDs with all the software you could imagine for a few HK\$. Obviously illegal, but that was hardly relevant there at that time. It was all about getting equal opportunity.

Nowadays, more and more software come as a (cloud) service — some are free, some pretty expensive. The IoT connects everything to the internet — from doorbells to thermometers, and even light bulbs. The four freedoms are now to be seen in conjunction with our right to privacy and security.

With the recent rise of AI in commercial applications, it will become equally important to have transparency of data sets, weightings, and algorithms if we want to ensure a fairly biased AI. It is also high time to think about decentralisation, prevention of vendor lock-in, open standards, transparency and the freedom to modify into these systems.

FN: What has been the response of India in particular and South Asia in general to SFD?

JG: In Southeast Asia, events have been organised in Kathmandu and Phnom Penh.

It is surprising that the booming country of India is still missing though... Maybe your city can make the difference?

 **Note:** You can connect with Jurgen Gaeremyn on +32496459541 through WhatsApp or Signal, or email him at jurgen@digitalfreedomfoundation.org.

END 

By: Frederick Noronha

The author is a Goa-based freelance journalist, who has been tracking FOSS (free and open source software), Creative Commons and the Wikipedia issues closely and intensely for a long time.

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Month	Theme
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April 2023	Open Source Programming (Languages and tools)
May 2023	Cloud Special: Everything from management to implementation
June 2023	AI, Deep learning and Machine Learning
July 2023	Database management and Optimisation
August 2023	Mobile/Web App Development, Optimisation and Security
September 2023	DevOps Special
October 2023	Blockchain and Open Source
November 2023	Open Source and IoT and Edge
December 2023	All About Data Management
January 2024	Containers and Managing Containers
February 2024	Open Source on Windows and Best in the world of Open Source (Tools and Services)